

Duck-billed platypus

Ornithorhynchus anatinus

With its ducklike bill, thick fur, and webbed feet, the platypus is one of Earth's most unusual animals, yet it possesses even more distinctive traits. One of just two living monotremes, or egg-laying mammals (the other is the echidna), the average body temperature of the platypus is 89.6°F (32°C), which is lower than most mammals, and its legs extend out, not down. These features are more common in reptiles. Males have a horny spur on the inside of each hind ankle that delivers a venomous sting to rivals vying for their breeding territory. Extremely painful to humans, the venom is strong enough to kill a domestic dog.

Sensory perception

A duckbilled platypus spends most of the day in its burrow, which it digs into an earth bank using its strong front claws. On land, the paddlelike webbing of the

front feet folds beneath them, allowing the platypus to walk. It emerges to feed at night, rootling through the muddy bottom of shallow pools, where it detects prey with its bill's highly sensitive electroreceptors. These are capable of spotting the tail-flick of a crayfish from 6–8 in (15–20 cm) away. The platypus stores all the food it catches in its cheek pouches, at the back of the jaw. When it surfaces to breathe, the platypus uses the horny pads and ridges in its mouth to grind up the food before swallowing.

Platypuses mate during spring, and the female lays up to three eggs in a nesting burrow about three weeks later. She incubates them until they hatch, then feeds the young with milk, although not from nipples like other mammals. Female platypuses ooze milk directly through the skin on either side of their belly; the milk is sucked up by their young.



- ↔ 16–22 in (41–56 cm)
- ⚖ 2–5 lb (1–2.3 kg)
- ⊗ Common
- 🐛 Insect larvae, crayfish
- 🏠 🌿 🌊



E. Australia, Tasmania

▽ SOME HOAX

Aboriginal legend says the platypus was born after a female duck mated with a water rat. When the first platypus skin arrived in Britain in 1799, it was thought to be a hoax.

waterproof coat
with dense underfur

smooth,
suedelike
skin covering



The **bill** of a platypus is **soft and rubbery**, not hard like a duck's